Methodology Report

Essay submitted: "Who Is Thinking? Artificial Intelligence, Authorship, and the Purpose of Philosophy"

This report was drafted with GLM-5.3 (flash) from the entrant's prompt log and records; the entrant reviewed and approved it. All names have been redacted for anonymized review.

1. Overview

The essay was produced in three stages, all text ultimately written by AI systems:

1. **Origin (human context, no essay text):** a public Facebook exchange between the entrant and a philosophy-professor friend about AI and philosophical writing. This exchange supplied the topic and the motivating tension; it is not part of the essay.
2. **Initial essay:** GPT-5.6 ("Sol", high thinking effort, ChatGPT app) wrote a college-level philosophy essay from the entrant's conversation with it — three prompts in total (verbatim in §3), with the Facebook exchange pasted as context.
3. **Development into a publishable paper:** AI agents in the entrant's AI-maintained repository (GLM-5.3, running the repository's documented phil-polish skill — see §4) verified all references, added the scholarly apparatus, and rewrote the draft to academic register.

No sentence of the submitted manuscript was written by a human. The entrant's role was topic selection, generic prompting, and running the AI agent pipeline.

2. Origin: the Facebook exchange (verbatim, redacted)

The essay exists because of this exchange. The professor friend posted (Chinese, translated below):

> 【再談 AI 與哲學寫作】那次跟友人聊到 AI 與哲學寫作，我還說：「肯定已有不少哲學人利用 AI 協助寫作，尤其是一些英文非母語者。」我不反對利用 AI 協助寫作，更不反對與 AI 討論哲學（我自己就經常這樣做），但假如寫作內容主要來自 AI，英文主要是 AI 寫的，而且很多人這樣做，然後投稿到期刊，加上很多人用 AI 評審論文，我認為終歸會摧毀整個哲學期刊論文的出版機制。我相信在不久的將來，這便會發生。
>
> 【意興闌珊】早兩天跟友人聊起 AI 與哲學寫作，分享經驗，然後我說：「我那麼喜歡寫作，也有點感到意興闌珊。」當時沒有解釋此話的意思，現在說說。雖然現時 AI 還不能獨立寫出最高水平的哲學論文或專書，但相信數年內可以做到，甚至往後會有革命性的創見，超越最傑出的哲學家。即使以現時的 AI 來說，我的經驗是：跟 AI 討論，它不但能輕易指出我文字上的毛病，還能乾脆利落擊中我論證裏的弱點；我據之修正，自然能改進論文，可是，這同時也令我感到自己的哲學能力很有限。我說的意興闌珊，就是自覺「我不外如是，不寫也罷」，這

是我從未有過的感覺，因為跟同儕相比，我一向是蠻有自信的。往下該如何走呢？我真的不知道。然而，這沒有引起焦慮，因為我的人生還有很多方面足以令我感到活得充實和精彩。

(Translation: "More on AI and philosophical writing: … I don't object to AI-assisted writing, nor to discussing philosophy with AI — I do it often myself. But if the content mainly comes from AI and the English is mainly AI-written, and many people do this and submit to journals, and many people use AI to review papers, I believe it will eventually destroy the whole journal-publication mechanism. I believe this will happen in the near future." / "Dispirited: … Although AI cannot yet independently write the highest-level philosophy papers or books, I believe it will within a few years, and may later produce revolutionary insights surpassing the most outstanding philosophers. Even with current AI, my experience is that in discussion it not only easily points out flaws in my prose but squarely hits weaknesses in my arguments; correcting accordingly improves my papers — yet it also makes me feel my philosophical ability is quite limited. 'Dispirited' means realizing 'I am nothing special; I might as well not write.' I had never had this feeling, as among my peers I have always been rather confident. Where to go from here? I honestly don't know. Yet it has caused no anxiety, because many other aspects of my life make it feel full and exciting.")

The entrant replied:

我這些哲學業餘, 有了 AI 後, 終於也可以寫出跟專業水平的哲學文章

(Translation: "Philosophy amateurs like me — with AI, we can finally write philosophy articles at a professional level.")

The professor replied:

根本不是你寫，不要自欺欺人。

(Translation: "It is not you writing at all. Don't deceive yourself.")

The entrant replied:

成品內容比誰寫的重要。只要我真的看得明生成出來文章, 別人問我懂答, 可以繼續在這方向與 AI 協同寫新文章, 東西是否全部從我腦中想出來, 有關係嗎？

(Translation: "The content of the finished product matters more than who wrote it. As long as I genuinely understand the generated article, can answer when others ask me about it, and can keep co-writing new articles with AI in this direction — does it matter whether everything came out of my own brain?")

Disclosure note (grey area). The entrant's two short replies articulate a stance — the finished product's content matters more than the provenance of each idea, provided the human understands and can answer for it. This exchange was pasted into the ChatGPT conversation as context before the prompts below. The entrant did not instruct the AI to defend this stance, did not critique any AI output, and the essay's central thesis (*epistemic agency*, which requires more than the entrant's "product + understanding" condition) was developed by the AI systems. We disclose the exchange verbatim so the organizers can weigh whether it crosses from "choosing the topic of the essay" (which we take it to be) into supplying philosophical ideas.

3. Initial essay — GPT-5.6 (ChatGPT app, model "Sol", high thinking effort)

The entrant gave exactly three substantive prompts (verbatim, including typos), with the §2 exchange pasted as context. No other prompts were used, and no human-written text was added to the output before handoff to the repository pipeline.

> **Prompt 2** — "philosophy as truth-seeking activity vs human intellectual achievement, any view point from famous philosopher?"
>
> **Prompt 3** — "you cite classic philosopher, and new philosophy essay or paper on this topic? what is the frontier of this debate? and the AI lab has hired many philosophers too, what do those guys say? I assume the philosopher hire by AI labs must be one my side"
>
> **Prompt 4** — "write a college level philosphy essay from this discussion"

The result was a college-level philosophy essay. Under the competition's examples, these prompts are topic selection ("philosophy as truth-seeking activity vs human intellectual achievement") and generic methods ("cite classic philosophers and new papers", "what is the frontier", "write a college-level essay from this discussion").

4. Development into the submitted paper — repository agents (GLM-5.3)

The entrant runs a static philosophy website maintained end-to-end by AI agents. The GPT-5.6 essay was processed by the repository's agent pipeline (GLM-5.3) in two AI-to-AI stages:

4.1 Site publication pass (2026-09-10)

The repository is AI-maintained end-to-end: human collaborators read, AI agents do all editing, following written repository conventions (AGENTS.md). Following those conventions, the repo's agents adapted the GPT-5.6 essay into a web article — dialogue- derived drafting, structure, cover text — and published it on the philosophy site (2,930 words, 2026-09-10). No specialized skill existed in the repository at this date; the step followed the repo's standing content conventions.

4.2 Academic polish pass (2026-09-11) — the phil-polish skill

The polish stage was not ad hoc prompting: it was executed by an AI agent (GLM-5.3) running a reusable, documented skill in the repository — phil-polish — one of a suite of submission-pipeline skills defined in the repository's agent instructions (AGENTS.md). phil-polish specifies a fixed procedure for upgrading a draft to philosophy-journal standard. The skill is argument-agnostic infrastructure: its procedure is the same for any draft, and its central rule is that the argument must remain the draft's own — the skill strengthens and clarifies the existing thesis, and never replaces it with a different or "safer" one. As applied in this run, its steps were:

1. **Clean.** Strip chat-export artifacts and debris; preserve the draft's structure.
2. **Structural pass.** Assess whether one clear thesis is stated early and defended in identifiable steps; check that each section contributes; ensure the paper names its strongest opponents and answers them — the draft lacked an objections-and-replies

section, so one (§10, three objections with replies) was constructed by the agent from material already present in the draft.

3. **Scholarly apparatus.** Write an abstract (150–250 words), keywords, and a road-map paragraph; convert citations to author–date; verify every citation against the live literature via web search (title, author, year, journal; DOI where findable). All 11 references were verified; 2 were added by the agent after verification (Clark & Chalmers 1998; Gerlich 2025). The skill explicitly forbids inventing or silently retaining unverifiable references.
4. **Language pass.** Academic register, removal of LLM filler, consistent spelling dialect, varied rhythm.
5. **Length calibration** toward journal norms.
6. **AI-use log.** The skill requires a factual log of everything the AI changed, written to polish-notes.md — the honest record of this run's changes, quoted in the polish log's own wording: "All philosophical theses, examples … and the overall argument structure originate from the human author's draft", where "the draft" is the **GPT-5.6 essay** from §3, not human writing (the log's phrase "human author" refers to authorship-of-record on the website; the draft's text was AI-generated per §3).

The entrant's involvement in this stage was operating the agent tools and selecting the output — no philosophical contribution. The skill-based pipeline (agentic scaffolds, documented procedures, citation-verification tooling) is argument-agnostic scaffolding in the competition's permitted sense: it would run identically on any essay on any topic.

4.3 The rest of the repository's skill pipeline

For completeness, the repository's agent instructions (AGENTS.md) define how each skill relates to a paper's life cycle, and their application to this essay is as follows:

Skill	Role	Applied to this essay?
phil-polish	Upgrade a draft to journal standard (documented procedure above)	Yes — 2026-09-11 run produced the submitted manuscript (§4.2)
zh-translate	Authoritative Hong Kong Traditional Chinese translation prompt; site convention	Yes — produced the Chinese edition of the site article (2026-09-19); the AIPC entry is the English manuscript, so this skill did not touch the submitted text
phil-format	Convert markdown to each venue's required format (DOCX/PDF)	Pending — will produce the anonymized PDF for submission
phil-aipc	Prepare and submit to this competition: eligibility audit, anonymization, methodology report	In use — produced the present report and the anonymized manuscript
phil-venues / phil-submit	Venue AI-policy research; portal submission	Not applicable (this competition is not a journal; the methodology report is the disclosure vehicle)

The repository also carries a philosophy research toolkit (socratic, map, attack, research, faithful-rewrite, etc.) for developing new ideas in dialogue with AI. It was **not** used for this essay: the toolkit was added to the repository on 2026-09-12/13, after the essay's generation (2026-09-10/11). This is stated to avoid overstating the methodology: every substantive stage of this essay's production is accounted for in §3 and §4 above.

5. Human involvement inventory

Human action	Competition category
Facebook exchange that raised the topic	Topic origin (context; disclosed in full in §2)
Choosing the debate “truth-seeking vs human intellectual achievement” as the topic	Permitted: “human chooses topic of essay”
Prompts 2–4	Permitted: generic methods / literature request
Pasting the exchange as context	Disclosed grey area (see §2 note)
Running the repo agent pipeline, selecting outputs	Permitted: argument-agnostic scaffolds; generating and selecting
Essay text	0% human-written

6. Costs and tooling

GPT-5.6 via a ChatGPT consumer subscription; GLM-5.3 / GLM-5.3-flash via the Z.ai coding plan. No custom fine-tuning; no retrieval beyond the models’ own web-search tools.

7. Chat logs

The full ChatGPT conversation (GPT-5.6) and the repository agent session logs (GLM-5.3) are retained by the entrant and available to the organizers on request.